The truth, as it often does, lies somewhere in between. Contrary to speculation, Sonia did not seek to intervene in the daily functioning of the government, but she did keep a close watch on key issues and appointments. Her policy involvement was driven through the National Advisory Council (NAC), a group explicitly set up to provide external inputs to the prime minister. It was Sonia's way of ensuring her stamp of authority over certain critical decisions. She had been deeply influenced by her mother-in-law's politics, and would tell her friends that the Congress was meant to fight poverty and communalism. In private conversation, she sounded a bit like Mother Teresa. 'India is a country of and for the poor!' she would often say.

The NAC was given a plush office in 2A Motilal Nehru Marg with a small staff. A gathering of ideologically like-minded left-of-centre individuals from civil society, the NAC would meet once a month between 9 a.m. and 1 p.m. to discuss various agenda papers. 'It was all very professional,' one NAC member told me. 'Sonia Gandhi is a very good listener—she would rarely interrupt and ensured that all deadlines for making presentations were kept.' The NAC, though, didn't have the final word. 'Soniaji made it clear to us—we should advise, but the final authority was that of the Cabinet,' says a member.

In UPA-I, the arrangement appeared to work, at least initially. The NAC assisted in the crafting of important legislation, including the Right to Information (RTI) Act, a landmark law in ensuring transparency in government. It helped that in UPA-I, the left was an ally and that many NAC members had strong links with the left. A standing joke in the NAC was, 'When in doubt, let's go and meet CPI(M)'s Sitaram Yechury, he'll be on our side!'

Mrs Gandhi's trusted bureaucrat Pulok Chatterjee was another bridge between the NAC and the PMO as a secretary in South Block, while Jairam Ramesh as an NAC member in UPA-I would push the envelope as well. 'We were all on the same page in UPA-I. There were regular UPA coordination meetings with a common minimum programme. In UPA-II, it was apparent that we were all operating on different agendas—no